

MESSAGE OF SUPPORT

Programme Director,

Minister for Public Service and Administration, Inkosi Buthelezi

Secretary and Chairperson Council,

PO of GEMS and PEO of GEPP

Representatives of the Employer,

Leaders of Organised Labour, COSATU and FEDUSA,

Allows me to follow the protocols that has been established

Distinguished Negotiators,

Colleagues and Comrades, Good morning.

On behalf of SAPU block which comprise of SAPU, NUPSAW and PEU, we extend our sincere appreciation for the invitation to deliver this message of support at this important Strategic Planning Session of the Public Service Coordinating Bargaining Council.

We gather under a powerful and timely theme:

“Collective Bargaining in the Digital Era: Building Trust, Managing Disputes, and Ensuring Good Governance.”

This theme is not vague. It speaks directly to the daily realities we face as negotiators, as leaders, and as custodians of labour relations in the public service.

Collective bargaining is not merely a process. It is not just a negotiation table, a resolution or an agreement signed at the end of difficult engagements.

Collective bargaining is the foundation of labour peace. It is the structured expression of power balanced by responsibility. It is where rights meet obligations. It is where dignity is defended.

In the public service, collective bargaining is the cornerstone of stability. Without it, we do not have partnership, we have confrontation.

As we deliberate over the next three days, let us reaffirm that the institution of collective bargaining must remain strong, credible, and protected. It must not be weakened by mistrust and it must not be rendered irrelevant by digital changes.

Instead it must evolve responsibly and strategically.

And as it evolves, we must never forget its primary purpose to protect and improve the working conditions of public servants.

Today public servants in this country are overworked and underpaid. They carry increasing workloads with shrinking resources. They serve communities under immense pressure, yet many of them are struggling to cope with the rising cost of living. Life is becoming more difficult for them on a daily basis.

One of the most critical matters before us at this moment is the sustainability and future of the Government Employees Medical Scheme (GEMS). The security of accessible and affordable healthcare for public servants is not a minor issue it is central to their dignity and wellbeing.

When medical aid becomes unstable or unaffordable, it affects not only employees, but their families. It affects morale. It affects productivity. It affects the very stability of the public service.

If we are serious about protecting working conditions, then we must treat the protection of GEMS and broader employee benefits as urgent priorities within our collective bargaining framework.

Trust is the currency of effective negotiation.

Yet trust is fragile. It is built slowly through transparency, consistency and respect. It is broken quickly through one side action, poor communication or failure to implement agreements.

If we are to build trust in this digital era, we must ensure that technology enhances not replaces human engagement. Virtual platforms, data systems, AI-assisted processes these tools must serve the principles of fairness and accountability.

Digital transformation cannot become digital exclusion.

Efficiency cannot come at the expense of consultation.

Speed cannot override justice.

Where there are two parties there will always be disputes, so the question is not whether disputes will arise.

The question is how we manage them.

Are we proactive or reactive?

Are we strategic or emotional?

Do we escalate too quickly, or do we exhaust all internal mechanisms first?

Trust is strengthened when agreements are honoured. When disputes are handled fairly. When information is shared openly. When all parties are treated with dignity even in disagreement.

Delayed justice erodes confidence.

We are living in a world where wars are being fought because negotiations collapse and parties fail to engage in good faith. Conflict escalates when dialogue breaks down. The lesson for us is clear: when negotiations are not conducted in good faith, instability follows.

If we, as leaders in collective bargaining, struggle to engage one another honestly and in good faith, we risk causing serious harm — not only for this generation of public servants, but for future generations who will inherit the systems we shape today.

As negotiators and leaders, we must cultivate a culture where dispute resolution is principled not politicised.

structured not chaotic.

and solution-driven not personality-driven.

We must show the people of this country that differences can be resolved through structured engagement. That strong views do not require hostility. That firmness does not require disrespect.

This strategic session must therefore ask hard questions:

Are our structures responsive enough?

Are we communicating effectively with our constituencies?

Are we modernising in ways that strengthen compliance and ethical conduct?

Good governance requires discipline from both the employer and organised labour.

We are living in a rapidly changing world. The digital era is reshaping workplaces, administrative systems and communication channels. The public service cannot remain same all the time.

Technology must enhance transparency.

It must improve efficiency without compromising confidentiality.

It must empower negotiators with better information, not change the balance of power.

Modernisation must strengthen the spirit of partnership — not erode it.

One of the most important objectives of this session is to develop a shared medium road map

But most importantly, partnership.

The PSCBC is not the employer alone.

It is not organised labour alone.

It is a joint institution built on co-determination and mutual recognition.

As SAPU, we offer our full support to this strategic planning process.

We encourage robust debate but respectful debate.j

We support innovation but principled innovation.

We support reform but reform that strengthens collective bargaining, not weakens it.

Let us engage honestly.

Let us challenge constructively.

Let us listen attentively.

And when we disagree as we will surely do, let us disagree with maturity and purpose.

Because beyond the negotiation tables and dispute files, there are public servants who rely on us to protect their rights, improve their conditions, safeguard their medical security and defend the integrity of the public service.

May this Strategic Planning Session of the Public Service Coordinating Bargaining Council be remembered not simply as another meeting — but as a defining moment where we recommitted ourselves to trust, to good governance, to good faith engagement and to a modern, credible, and resilient collective bargaining system.

SAPU stands in support of this process.

We wish you productive deliberations over the next three days.

I thank you.